



BOB KNOX
... Bounces Back

Bob Knox Fights Back Miner Hurler Turns Future Around

By FLIP MORIN
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You'd think two years ago Bob Knox would have had his fill of University of Texas at El Paso baseball pitching. He'd really bombed on the mound. His delivery should have arrived by short-order cook.

The only thing he showed coach Andy Cohen as a freshman out of Chicago, Ill., was a plane ticket stub for his baggage.

Cohen found out his prize freshman from Mendel Catholic High, where he won four and lost one in his senior year, wasn't doing much. His attitude was devil-may-care (it was in time with the team that year: 12-39 on the year and 1-17 in the WAC) and through 25 innings his "Windy City" style didn't impress the Brothers Cohen.

So Knox's scholarship went to the bottom of the dusty ballbag and Knox returned to Chicago.

But that wasn't the end of the determined young right hander's baseball story.

He fought back, proved himself and last year capped his junior year for the Miners by hurling a perfect game against New Mexico Highlands (U.T. El Paso won 1-0) in seven innings and led the entire nation in National Collegiate Athletic Association stats for five weeks with a 0.00 earned run average.

"I just wanted to prove to coach Cohen that he was wrong in dropping me," Knox revealed. "I know I was wrong with that lackadaisical attitude when I was a freshman, so I fought back real hard to have my scholarship re-enstated."

Despite his mother's insistence that he remain in Chicago and transfer to school there (he's a management major and plans on attending law school after graduation from U.T. El Paso where his 3.5 GPA is now secure), Knox played in a local league during the summer, establishing a 9-4 record.

"I contacted coach Cohen and told him I had made up my mind to win, I had worked hard all summer, and that I was a new person," Knox said. "Staying in school and continuing my education was the most important thing in my life at that point, and I knew baseball was the key to it."

Cohen relented and Knox reported for the 1973 campaign.

"I was really down when I left in May after that bad showing," Knox recalled. "But my spirits weren't shot skyward when I found out they didn't even have a uniform for me."

That's right, Knox, who would perform outstanding feats on the mound for the Miners, was outfitted in one of the team's old grey uniforms, sporting a black cap while the rest of the team displayed orange and white of more traditional hues.

Yet, Syd worked out with Knox in perfecting his delivery some and he sat out about a dozen games until Andy gave him some action.

Against Denver he shut them out and gave up only four hits.

One week later, with much control on his curve, fast ball and slider, he delivered the perfect game against the Cowboys. He ended the year at 3-2 with a 2.06 ERA.

"I like to keep the batters off stride by mixing up my stuff," Knox stated. "I'm primarily a control pitcher, actually I don't have that many strikeouts."

It was a tough road back for Knox, but he proved to himself and to the Miners that he was capable of standing tall on the mound.

"As I recall it, he was a bright kid with talent who thought he'd come to El Paso on that free-ride scholarship," Cohen said. "He didn't show us much out there on the pitcher's mound, only that he could throw the ball, good at times, but most of the time he wasn't in command."

"We had about 10 pitchers on the team that year, but I wanted more so we took Knox on. But after that disastrous season

that he showed us, I pulled his scholarship. But he came back and proved himself and now he's one of our mainstays."

Knox lost against Highlands last week when the Miners were edged 5-4, but took a 9-1 decision on five hits from the Aggies of New Mexico State. In that one, they didn't score on him until the final inning.

Dave Jannusch will get the starting assignment 2 p.m. Thursday as the Miners host the Pioneers from Denver at Dudley Field. Jannusch (0-1) has gone 8 1-3 innings, faced 34 batters and given up nine runs while striking out four.

Denver returns for another single game Friday, then the Miners host Northern Colorado in a doubleheader 1 p.m. Saturday at Dudley.

Denver lists 23 players on the roster, 14 of them lettermen, although Kevin Iverson, a letterman right-handed pitcher, is limping with a knee injury suffered in basketball.

Senior lefty John Blair will get the mound assignment against the Miners.

Coach Jack Rose and his team — the largest in his 13 seasons as head mentor — are on a southern swing of 12 games, meeting five teams in three states.

After 11 games, Bob Downing, the big first baseman, and Glen Villarreal at third, are tied with .344 for top Miner stickmen. Downing has accounted for 13 RBI's on three home runs and two doubles. Villarreal, with 11 runs, pounded out three two-sackers and one triple for five RBI's.

Both players have 11 hits apiece.

Second baseman Mark Miller is next at .324 from 12 hits including two homers and a double for three RBI's and 11 runs.

Tony Medellin heads the hurlers with a 1.46 ERA off two wins and no losses. He's gone 12 1-3 innings, given up 11 hits and struck out two.

Wils Open Tourney

State, 19-7, and Bradley, 19-7, collide in the other first round game.

Semifinals of the tourney, making its debut at the 19,000-seat Arena, will be Sunday afternoon.